

External partners. Connect the outside

A nine-part series on what has to be true before AI is worth pointing at your business. Part one is about getting a trading partner's data through the door at all.

Years ago, someone asked me why connecting a new supplier's system to ours was going to take six weeks. I gave her the honest, technically complete answer: certificates need issuing, field mappings need agreeing, test messages need sending back and forth until everyone trusts the pipe. All true. All also, I later realised, not what she was actually asking, which was closer to: why does the twenty-first century still run on this?

It runs on this because the cost of a slow supplier onboarding never appears on an invoice. Nobody's monthly report has a line item for "three weeks lost to certificate exchange." And a cost nobody measures is a cost nobody fixes, however real it is at the other end.

Picture the actual mechanics. Two people, one at your company and one at the new partner's, emailing spreadsheets back and forth (this one has the wrong delimiter, that one is missing a field, try again) until eventually something goes through cleanly enough that everyone agrees to call it done. This is, by any honest description, a manual process wearing a digital costume.

It is tempting, especially with regulators suddenly obsessed with one particular document type, to think of all this as an invoicing problem. It isn't, and treating it as one would be a bit like reducing your whole electrical installation to the doorbell. The invoice is one entry on a long, unglamorous menu of things two companies' computers need to agree on before they can talk sense to each other: purchase orders, order confirmations, dispatch and delivery notices, demand forecasts, remittance advice, packaging and label data, even the engineering drawing that has to reach a supplier before they can build the part you ordered.

It helps to keep three separate questions apart here, because people, and vendors, conflate them constantly. What is actually being said is one question: an order, a despatch advice, an invoice, a CAD drawing, each described by a standard like EDIFACT, X12, VDA or ENG DAT. That's the cargo. How the content is wrapped so a machine can open it is a different question entirely: XML, JSON, CSV, PDF, and the same cargo happily fits inside more than one of them. That's the truck. And which route it travels by, AS2, OFTP, SFTP, HTTPS, is a third question again, usually decided by whichever partner has the stronger opinion, which is rarely you. That's the highway. Get the cargo description wrong and it doesn't matter how fast the truck is. Get the truck wrong and a perfectly good highway carries nothing useful. This is also why "just build an API" is never quite the whole answer: an API is a highway, not a cargo manifest.

 **Cargo**
The interchange standard: what is actually being said.
EDIFACT · X12 · VDA · ENG DAT

 **Truck**
The general data format: how the content is wrapped so a machine can open it.
XML · JSON · CSV · PDF

 **Highway**
The communication protocol: the route and its rules of the road, usually chosen by the partner.
AS2 · OFTP · SFTP · HTTPS

 The table below is about the cargo, the layer that actually varies by industry, since that's the part worth knowing by name:

STANDARD	TYPICAL INFORMATION EXCHANGED	FOCUS INDUSTRIES
EDIFACT	Purchase orders, dispatch and delivery notices, invoices, demand forecasts, inventory reports	Manufacturing, retail, logistics (broad cross-industry use)
VDA (4905/4915/4994)	Delivery schedules and forecasts, delivery notes, invoices, packaging and label data	Automotive manufacturing
ZUGFeRD / XRechnung / Factur-X	Structured invoice data (line items, tax, payment terms) plus a human-readable PDF	Cross-industry e-invoicing compliance

 Further reading — I've written at greater length about this particular alphabet soup, cargo, trucks and highways all included, in an earlier [post](#), if the full taxonomy is what you're after.

Invoices simply happen to be the one item on that menu currently attracting a regulator's attention, which is why it's worth being precise about the dates. For a long time you could shrug the whole connectivity problem off as an efficiency question, the kind of thing you get around to when there's budget for it. That window is closing for invoices specifically, and not because anyone had a change of heart about efficiency. It is closing because several European tax authorities decided, independently and on their own schedules, to make onboarding a partner and staying compliant the same task:

THE NATIONAL DEADLINES

Germany

Jan 2025 → Jan 2028

Germany already requires every business to be able to receive e-invoices, since January 2025. Issuing them becomes mandatory from January 2027 for larger businesses, and for everyone else a year after that.

Belgium

Jan 2026

Belgium moves in one step rather than several: from January 2026, nearly every VAT registered business trading with another business must issue e-invoices, with no exemption for being small.

Poland

Feb 2026 → Jan 2027

Poland's system arrives in three separate waves rather than two, which is the sort of detail that gets lost in the first draft of any compliance memo: large taxpayers from February 2026, most other businesses from April 2026, and micro-entrepreneurs from January 2027.

Denmark

Jul 2026 → Jan 2027

Denmark's date has moved around in various compliance summaries doing the rounds, but the authority's own position is that e-invoicing becomes the default from July 2026 for businesses using a registered bookkeeping system, with a further reporting requirement arriving the following January.

None of these are the same rule, on the same date, for the same size of company. That is precisely the point. A patchwork is harder to plan for than a single hard deadline, because there is no single date to put in the diary and forget about.

And behind the whole patchwork sits a bigger one, arriving later and caring rather less about your size. From July 2030, the EU's own cross-border e-invoicing and digital reporting mandate takes effect under what is being called VAT in the Digital Age, and it comes with no exemption for small or medium sized businesses at all. The national deadlines are the warm-up act.

Here is the part worth sitting with for a second.



None of this was ever really about invoices. Invoices just happen to be the first item on the menu to get a deadline stapled to it. The purchase orders, the forecasts, the delivery notices, the engineering files, all still moving through the same slow, manual, format-specific handshake, are costing you exactly as much as they did before any regulator noticed. While this regulation didn't create the cost, it still put a deadline on top of a cost you'd already decided to live with.

What the fix actually is

The fix is not, thankfully, a bigger IT project than it sounds. It is a layer that speaks the cargo, adapts to whatever truck it arrives in, and doesn't much care which highway was used, sitting between you and whoever you're trading with, so that onboarding a new partner becomes a configuration exercise rather than a six week correspondence. Whether that partner sends you a VDA delivery forecast over AS2, an EDIFACT dispatch notice as a flat file over SFTP, or a PDF invoice someone still insists on emailing, the mechanism that receives it should not care, and neither, ideally, should you.

None of which answers the other half of the question, the one people usually ask right after this one: fine, the data can get in, but can I trust what's inside it once it arrives? That is tomorrow's problem, and it turns out to be a different problem entirely (at least giving me 24h to write about it...).

SOURCES

1. European Commission, Digital Building Blocks, "eInvoicing in Germany."
2. Belgian federal government, official e-invoicing portal (einvoice.belgium.be).
3. EY, "Poland signs into law mandatory national e-invoicing system" (KSeF).
4. KPMG US, "Denmark: latest work and 2026 agenda for digital bookkeeping and e-invoicing."
5. KPMG, "VAT in the Digital Age (ViDA): EU Reform Guide."



NEXT — CHAPTER 2, CORE SYSTEMS

Getting a partner's data through the door is only half the job. What happens to it once it's inside, and whether you can trust it enough to let AI near it, is where the argument goes next.